The Nap Is Gone and Nobody Is Okay

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The nap died on a random Tuesday. My daughter was 3, and for a week straight she'd lie in her bed singing to herself for an hour — full concerts, I could hear her through the door doing all the verses of songs I didn't know she knew — and then pop up cheerful and completely un-rested. The nap was over. I just didn't want to admit it yet.

So I spent two weeks trying to force it back. Darker curtains. White noise. Earlier lunch. Later lunch. Rocking her like a baby, which at 3 years old mostly meant her kicking me in the ribs. Nothing worked. Every "nap time" ended with both of us frustrated, and then she'd be wired until 10pm. That was flop number one: the nap wasn't coming back, and fighting it was ruining our afternoons.

What the end of the nap actually gave us: the 5pm meltdown. Every single day, like clockwork. She'd cry because her banana broke in half. She'd cry because her sock felt "wrong." Once she cried for twenty minutes because I cut her toast into triangles instead of squares. I started dreading 5 o'clock the way other people dread Monday mornings.

Here's what saved us. Two things.

Quiet time. Non-negotiable, every day, 1pm to 2pm. She goes to her room — not as punishment, her room is nice — with a stack of books and her stuffed animals, and the rule is she doesn't have to sleep, but she stays in there. I set a timer she can see. The first week she screamed at the door for twenty minutes. I sat outside it reading my own book so she'd know I was there. By week two she was "reading" to her bear. It's not sleep, but it's rest — for both of us. I get an hour to be a person, and she gets an hour to recharge without the pressure of performing sleep.

Earlier bedtime. This was the big one. We moved bedtime from 8pm to 7pm, and I mean lights-out 7pm, not "start thinking about bed" 7pm. It felt absurdly early. But a 3-year-old running on no nap cannot make it to 8 — by 7:30 she was feral. The earlier bedtime killed the 5pm meltdowns almost completely, because she wasn't running on fumes by evening anymore.

Flop number two, honorable mention: letting her “rest” on the couch at 6pm. She fell asleep, obviously, woke up at 7:30 fresh as a daisy, and was up until 10:30 doing laps around the living room. Never again.

I miss the nap. I’ll say it. That two-hour midday break was the load-bearing wall of my entire day, and quiet time isn’t the same — I can hear her narrating elaborate dramas to her stuffed animals in there. But nobody’s crying over toast geometry anymore, bedtime takes twenty minutes instead of two hours, and we’re all, mostly, okay.